Subject-Sharing Coordinate Constructions in Germanic Languages

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Abstract: This short paper argues against the coordination of intermediate projections and against the claim that the conjuncts of an obligatory subject-sharing coordinate construction in Germanic languages have no subject. In pursuing a well-formed syntactic structure of such a construction, it is suggested that a sideward movement of the subject from the low conjunct to the structure of the high conjunct can derive the major syntactic properties of the construction.

Keywords: obligatory sharing of subject, coordination, Germanic, intermediate projection, sideward movement

A particular coordinate construction in Germanic languages is shown in (1) (ILL = illative).

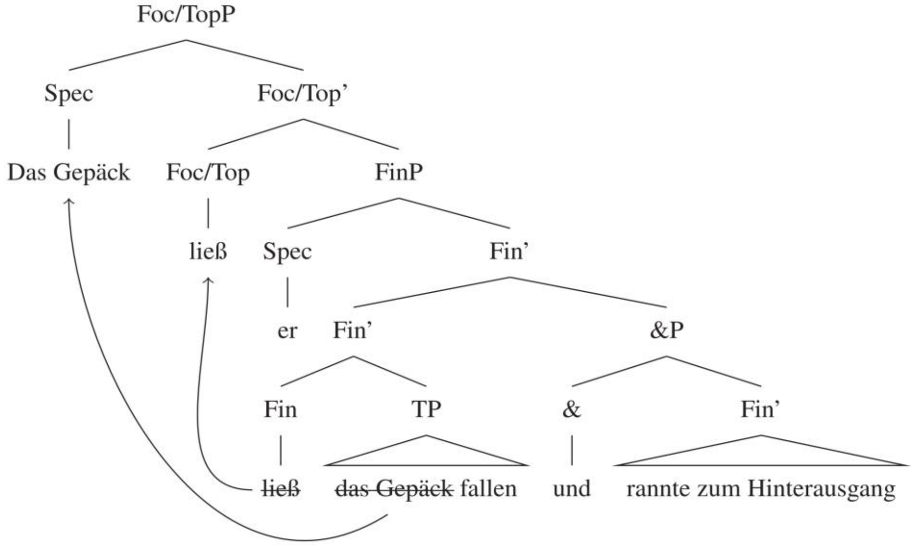
(1) a. Das Gepäck ließ er fallen und rannte zum Hinterausgang. *German*
the luggage let he drop and ran to.the back.exit
'He dropped the luggage and ran to the back exit.' (Höhle 1983)

b. Metsa läks jahimees ja tappis jänese. *Dutch*
forest.ILL went Hunter and killed hare
'The hunter went into the forest and killed a hare.' (Harbusch et al. 2009: 27)

Major syntactic properties of such constructions include, first, the first conjunct has the V2 order and second one has the V1 order; second, the gap in the second conjunct must be that of a subject, and it must be coindexed with the subject of the first conjunct; third, the first element in the first conjunct cannot be the subject. Since the two conjuncts must share their subject, let us call the construction Subject-Sharing Coordinate Construction

Challenging various previous analyses, Xu (2026) proposes the structure in (2) for (1a).

(2) (Xu 2026: 28)



There are two flaws in (2). One is that the two conjuncts linked by the conjunction *und* are both Fin’, an intermediate projection. As we know, the distinction between a maximal and an intermediate projection is relative. When there is no Spec element, the constituent formed by a head and its complement is always viewed as a maximal projection. An element is X’ only when its sister is the Specifier of the same projection (cf. Chomsky 1970). In (2), the sister of the T’ for the second conjunct is &, and the sister of the T’ for the first conjunct is &P. Neither & nor &P is a Specifier element. Thus, the two conjuncts cannot be Fin’. Xu tries to extend Zhang’s (2006) claim that conjuncts can be of any categorial levels, including clause, phrase, word, and even affix. But Zhang does not claim that conjuncts can be intermediate projections. Thus, the syntactic status of the conjuncts in (2) is problematic.

The second flaw in (2) is that both the first and the second conjunct is claimed to be subjectless, and thus a subject is assumed to be shared in a high position (SpecFinP in (2)). It is well-recognized that a subject is base-generated in vP (or VoiceP), and then is raised to SpecTP. One might claim that the subject of the first conjunct is raised out of the vP, reaching a higher position in (2). However, it is not clear how the subject in the second conjunct is associated with the subject of the first conjunct (the second major property introduced above) in this structure. The Fin’ for the second conjunct should be projected far above vP, which contains a low copy of the subject. Moreover, for a transitive expression, as seen in the second conjunct *tappis jänese* ‘killed hare’ in (1b), it is a VP that has no subject. A VP is below vP. But since the second conjunct in the construction surfaces as a verb-initial string (see the first major property introduced above), which means that the highest verbal element has moved out of vP, the conjunct cannot be a VP.

One alternative analysis is that the obligatory sharing of the subjects between the two conjuncts in the construction is derived by sideward movement (e.g., Nunes 2001; Hornstein & Nunes 2002). After the TP of the low conjunct is built, the subject DP undergoes a sideward movement to another working site, where the high conjunct is built. Specifically, this DP is integrated as the subject of the high conjunct. For (1a), *er* is base-generated as a subject in the low conjunct, as part of a vP, and then it moves to SpecTP. After that, it undergoes a sideward movement to another working site, becoming the subject of the high conjunct, also as part of a vP. After the TP is built for the high conjunct, the two TP are conjoined by *und*. In this complex TP, the verb of the high conjunct moves to Foc/Top and a non-subject element moves to Spec of Foc/TopP. The steps to build (1a) are in (3).

(3) Step 1: in Working Site A, a TP is built, where the subject moves from vP to SpecTP, and the verb moves to T:

[$_{\text{TP-A}}$ ~~er~~$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ rannte$_i$ [$_{\text{vP-A}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_i$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_i$ zum Hinterausgang]]]]]

Step 2: in Working Site B, after a VP is built, *er* moves from Working Site A to Working Site-B, to be merged as the subject there:

[$_{\text{vP-B}}$ er$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ ließ$_j$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_j$ Das Gepäck fallen]]]

Step 3: in Working Site B, the vP grows into a TP, where the verb is raised to T (as in the other conjunct) and *er* is raised to SpecTP:

[$_{\text{TP-B}}$ er$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ ließ$_j$ [$_{\text{vP-B}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_j$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_j$ Das Gepäck fallen]]]]]

Step 4: the two TPs are conjoined by *und*:

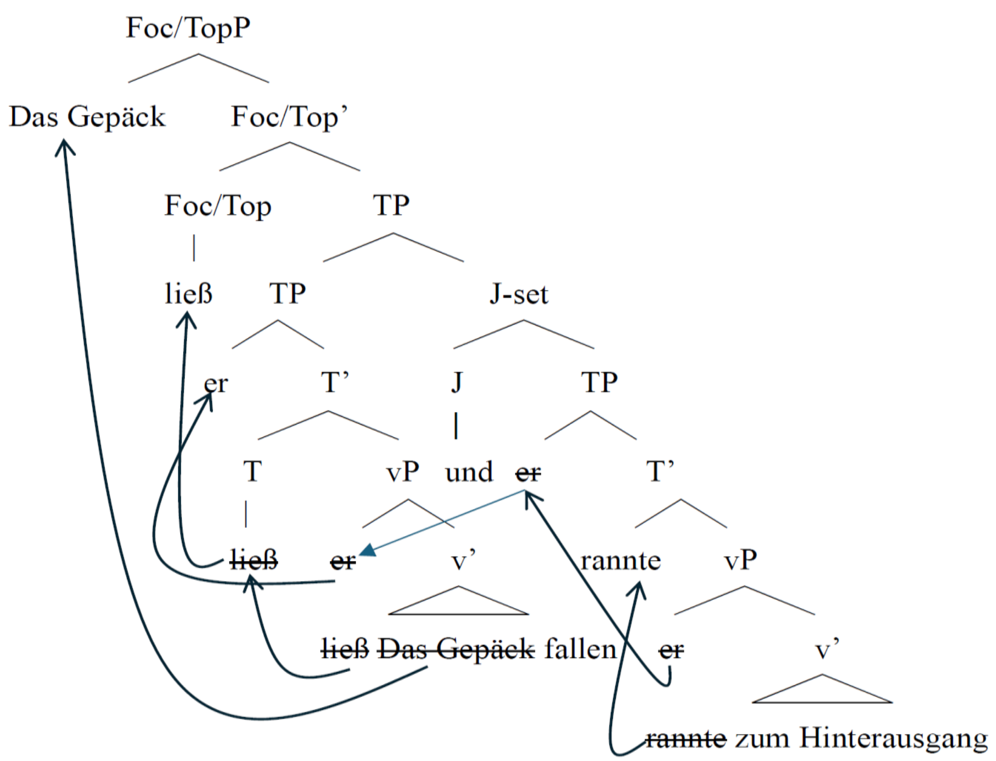
[$_{\text{TP-B}}$ er$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ ließ$_j$ [$_{\text{vP-B}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_j$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_j$ Das Gepäck fallen]]]]] und
[$_{\text{TP-A}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ rannte$_i$ [$_{\text{vP-A}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_i$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_i$ zum Hinterausgang]]]]]

Step 5: The verb *ließ* in the first conjunct moves to Foc/Top and *Das Gepäck* in the first conjunct moves to SpecFoc/TopP:

[$_{\text{Foc/TopP}}$ Das Gepäck$_g$ [$_{\text{Foc/Top'}}$ ließ$_j$ [$_{\text{TP-B}}$ er$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ t$_j$ [$_{\text{vP-B}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_j$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_j$ t$_g$ fallen]]]]] und
[$_{\text{TP-A}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ rannte$_i$ [$_{\text{vP-A}}$ t$_k$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_i$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_i$ zum Hinterausgang]]]]]]]

The whole derivation is illustrated in the tree in (4).

(4)



In (4), instead of the &P in (2), I use the label J-set for the combination of the coordinator and the low conjunct. In Zhang (2023), a low conjunct is the complement of the functional element Junct (J), which has no syntactic category and can be realized by a coordinator. The combination of J and its complement is called J-set, which is also categoryless. It is the high conjunct that projects the category for the whole coordinate structure. In (4), the high conjunct is a TP, and thus the coordinate structure is a TP. See Zhang (2023) for detailed argumentation for this J theory for coordination, although this new view of coordination does not affect either Xu's or my argumentation in this paper.

The new analysis in (3)/(4) is able to capture the major syntactic properties of Subject-Sharing Coordinate Constructions. First, the V2 order of the first conjunct is derived after the verb moves out of the conjunct and lands at Foc/Top, and an element of the conjunct moves to SpecFoc/TopP. Also, the V1 order of the second conjunct is derived by the raising of the verb to T. The movement of the verb to T occurs in both conjuncts. This account of the word order is compatible with Xu's account. Second, in the low conjunct, only the subject can move to SpecTP. Then, since it is this subject that moves to the vP of the other conjunct, the gap in the low conjunct must be that of a subject, and it must be co-indexed with the subject of the high conjunct. This captures the second major property of the construction. As for the constraint that only a non-subject can move to SpecFoc/Top, neither Xu (2026) nor this short paper has an account. But the new analysis here can keep all the empirical merits of Xu (2026) and avoid the two fundamental flaws mentioned above.

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